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"A Scandal in Bohemia" and Sherlock Holmes's Ultimate Mystery Solved

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IN "A SCANDAL IN BOHEMIA," the first Sherlock Holmes story, published in 1891, Holmes is upstaged and tricked, for the first and the last time, by a woman.[1] The story involves the beautiful and cunning Irene Adler, a retired opera singer and "well-known adventuress"[2] and the hapless King of Bohemia, her former lover. The Monarch plans to marry someone of his own rank: consequently, Ms Adler threatens to ruin his betrothal by exhibiting a compromising photograph of the couple. The King hires Holmes to find the ruinous evidence, and using one of his famous schemes the detective discovers the exact location of the photo in Adler's sitting room. Both men return the next morning to retrieve the object, only to find Adler and the photograph gone. She has, however, left a snapshot of herself and a letter for Holmes, promising never to release the damaging item. This is the only time when "the best plans of Mr. Sherlock Holmes were beaten by a woman's wit."[3]

Upon learning that he has been fooled by a woman, Holmes is embarrassingly "white with chagrin and surprise,"[4] an odd and uncharacteristically emotional reaction from the brightest detective in the country, known for his coolness and composure. The trauma and the impact of that failure are so great on Holmes that, years later, he still cannot bring himself to refer to Adler by name, calling her "*the* woman"[5] instead. At the close of the case, Holmes also behaves strangely when, in an unusually sentimental gesture, he asks to keep the photograph of Adler as payment of services rendered, in lieu of a valuable emerald ring. This selfless gesture is even more extraordinary when one remem-

bers how adamant Holmes had been about payment at the beginning of the story. When he first sees the King, the detective remarks that "there's money in this case;"[6] the fee is then discussed with great intensity as Holmes inquires "as to money?" to which the Sovereign replies, "you have carte blanche. . . . I would give one of the provinces of my kingdom to have that photograph." Holmes insists "and for present expenses?" He then gets "three hundred pounds in gold and seven hundred in notes."[7] The request seems even stranger as Holmes already possesses a memento of Adler: when he served as a surprise witness to her hasty marriage "the bride gave me a sovereign, and I mean to wear it on my watch-chain in memory of the occasion."[8]

But let us examine Irene Adler more in depth. In light of the common Victorian perception of woman as either housewife or harlot, Adler obviously belongs in the second category and thus quite literally epitomizes the nineteenth-century myth of the *femme fatale*, as "she was a lovely woman, with a face that a man might die for."[9] Nineteenth-century woman is seen as alien and alienating, an outsider, or, to use Freud's term, "a dark continent," and the element of foreignness, of otherness always associated with that type of woman, is a recurring theme in "A Scandal in Bohemia."[10] Most obviously, Adler was "born in New Jersey in the year 1858,"[11] and has lived in several European cities. Her romances similarly have an international flair; she had an affair with a German heir, and later married a British lawyer. In fact, the story is peppered with references to foreign places, from Bohemia to Warsaw.[12] On a more subtle level, Adler's alien status comes out doubly in her name, as Adler is German and means eagle; she is thus not only associated with a different nation but a different species. Adler's residence also reinforces the animal connotation, as she lives on Serpentine Avenue, a detail referred to on countless occasions.

Adler's menacing nature is likewise revealed through a duality of female physiology and male psychology. The King remarks that "she has the face of the most beautiful of women, and the mind of the most resolute of men."[13] She also freely crosses gender barriers by wearing men's clothing, confessing that "male costume is nothing new to me. I often take advantage of the freedom which it gives."[14] Aside from the benefit mentioned, the disguise affords Adler something even more important: power. As Jasmine Yong Hall notes, "women in the Holmes stories . . . are a conduit for male power. As the object of sexual dominance, they are necessary to release that power. But they do not

acquire power themselves; it is, instead, passed on to Holmes."[15] Women are powerless entities in all stories, except in "A Scandal in Bohemia," where Adler's active male role gives rise to her empowerment; as Adler takes center stage "she eclipses and predominates the whole of her sex."[16] Holmes further notes her universal mesmerizing effect: "she has turned all the men's heads down in that part. She is the daintiest thing under a bonnet on this planet."[17] Adler is truly a unique woman, and the King's laudatory cry of "What a woman—oh, what a woman!"[18] is also shared by Holmes. As Watson remarks, "there was but one woman for him, and that woman was the late Irene Adler."[19]

The powerful combination of foreign-alien, human-animal and male-female elements render Adler even more complex and incomprehensible to Holmes, who notes that "women are naturally secretive, and they like to do their own secreting."[20] Yet, in a blatant show of contradiction, the male protagonists are the ones hiding behind a constant veil of secrecy: Holmes himself confesses that he aims to draw "the veil from men's motives and actions."[21] Watson, while covertly plotting against Adler, is overcome with guilt and frets that "I never felt more heartily ashamed of myself in my life than when I saw the beautiful creature against whom I was conspiring."[22] The King at first also hides his face and his true identity, traveling "incognito from Prague," wearing "a black vizard mask"[23] and purporting to be one Count Von Kramm. Finally, Holmes, The Master of Secrecy, first refuses to disclose his *modus operandi* to Watson, then masquerades as a beggar and a clergyman. Both genders use camouflage, yet there are crucial differences. Adler changes her identity to her clear advantage, realizing that only a male disguise can afford her freedom and power, thereby (temporarily) enhancing her status. The men, on the other hand, are demeaned and lowered by their disguises: Watson feels guilt and shame; the Sovereign's cover demotes his regal status; and Holmes's costumes are always a tool of deception, turning him into a lowly trickster figure. As Pasquale Accardo notes in *Diagnosis and Deception*, "these carefully crafted alternative personae always seem to have something criminal about them: their purpose is concealment, trickery, deceit."[24]

"A Scandal in Bohemia" relies on an initial displacement from male to female, as a woman takes the lead, eclipses and defeats the males in the story. But a second similar shift occurs, this time involving the detective; thus the duality and deception first revolving around Adler are later shifted onto Holmes. A close analysis of the story reveals a

surprising set of contradictions and paradoxes in the lead male character. The detective is introduced as "the most perfect reasoning and observing machine," and "all emotions . . . were abhorrent to his cold, precise, but admirably balanced mind;"[25] yet every one of these terms is later subverted, emphasizing the human fallible side of the character, which we rarely get to see again in later stories. The detective does show *emotion* (hate) as he "loathed every form of society."[26] A more positive, almost sentimental side also comes out, as Holmes's *coldness* is disproved by the two keepsakes. His *precision* is refuted by his numerous miscalculations; and finally his *admirably balanced mind* is negated by his "drug-created dreams."[27]

Other instances of binary oppositions involving Holmes abound. The King notes that the person who was "depicted to him as the most incisive reasoner and most energetic agent in Europe" is a "languid, lounging figure."[28] Holmes reprimands Watson, remarking that "you see, but you do not observe. . . . I have both seen and observed."[29] Yet later the critic fails to apply his own tactic to the case at hand, for had he "seen and observed" he would have recognized Adler in disguise, and deduced her plans to flee. Furthermore, when Holmes and his client pay an early surprise visit to Adler in order surreptitiously to retrieve the picture, the detective confidently speculates that by the time Adler comes down to greet them "she may find neither us nor the photograph;"[30] but instead of fooling Adler, they are fooled by her, as she has, by that time, long left the country with the evidence.

Holmes is clearly off-balance and decentered, suffering from a loss of power which has been transferred to Adler. His eccentricity is played out on two levels. His "Bohemian soul,"[31] his odd personality and his unusual behavior fit the common dictionary definition of an eccentric. But he also fits the second definition of the term, meaning off-center; he is eccentric (removed from the center) as opposed to concentric. For instance, in *A Study in Scarlet* (the first Holmes novella) Holmes describes himself this way, as "the only one in the world. I'm a consulting detective."[32] The decentering state is repeated in "A Scandal in Bohemia" (the first Holmes short story). Holmes's uncharacteristic reversal from reasoned to unreasoned mind, from objective fact finding to subjective guessing is further emphasized by the shift from winning to losing. "A Scandal in Bohemia" is the first and only story where Holmes is defeated by anyone.[33] Although he does not technically lose the case since the initial purpose, the non-exposure of the scandal, is achieved, it remains

nevertheless a personal failure for Holmes for success is accomplished not on the detective's but on Adler's terms.[34]

The question is: why is this Victorian sleuth fooled by anyone at all, since he boasts a keen and infallible, although abstract, understanding of the human psyche? But therein lies the answer. He fails to win this case, for his opponent is someone whose mind he cannot understand. Professor Moriarty, for example, in many ways a darker alter-ego of Holmes, is the one criminal the detective can deal with. In "Charles Augustus Milverton" Holmes even confesses that he himself "would have made a highly efficient criminal."[35] Holmes's attitude towards Adler is, on the contrary, based on difference, as she is, by virtue of her gender, behaviorally and genetically other and therefore inscrutable (according to Victorian standards). Furthermore, as a woman Adler does not play by the (male) rules. Holmes points this out in some sweeping generalizations: "women are never to be entirely trusted-not the best of them";[36] he further states that he is "not a whole-souled admirer of womankind";[37] "he disliked and distrusted the sex,"[38] for "one of the most dangerous classes in the world . . . is the drifting and friendless woman."[39] All this testifies to his "aversion to women."[40]

Holmes's inability to understand woman is due to the element of difference, of otherness, which ties in with the outsider theme noted earlier. Time and again he will ponder the enigma of the female gender, as "woman's heart and mind are insoluble puzzles to the male,"[41] echoing Freud (another detective of sorts), who remarked that "throughout history people have knocked their heads against the riddle of the nature of femininity."[42] For Holmes, Woman, embodied by Adler, is a mystery wrapped in a riddle, an observation later made famous by Freud's cliché of "what does a woman want?"[43] All this affords the detective a convenient explanation for his defeat, for seen in this light, the case appears doomed from the outset, since Holmes is faced with his own riddle of the Sphinx. Adler's dual female-animal (eagle) attributes reinforce her monstrous affiliation to the winged Sphinx. As Holmes is unable to solve the riddle of the case, and of woman, all his subsequent adventures (especially the ones involving female leads) may be interpreted as an attempt, a quest, to unravel the enigma of the Adler Sphinx.

Holmes's incomprehension of Adler is shown throughout the case, as he makes an unusual number of mistakes, miscalculations and false assumptions. His first remark upon seeing the Monarch is "there's money in this case, Watson, *if there is nothing else*" (emphasis added).[44]

The latter part of the sentence foreshadows the detective's blindness (linking him even more to the Sphinx as a helpless Oedipus figure), since the case is precisely *not* about money but about the undefined *else*, which will turn out to be the enigma of Woman. Throughout the investigation, Holmes will consistently ignore or misread important clues, which is striking and puzzling, when one remembers the meticulous deductions he routinely makes at the start of any given case. This is emphasized when he miserably fails to pick up on easy and obvious clues concerning Adler, and at the same time makes accurate yet useless (for the case at hand) inferences about Watson's life. This causes the doctor to remark that "you would certainly have been burned, had you lived a few centuries ago."[45] Having a file on Adler, and knowing her to be an exceptionally shrewd woman, Holmes should be wary, and deduce that she may well be aware of the Monarch's plans. Yet Holmes fails to make that simple analysis, which then costs him the case. As soon as Adler discovers the plot, she follows the detective home and boldly hails him good night, whereupon the otherwise perspicacious Holmes pathetically ponders, "I wonder who the deuce that could have been."[46] The detective is literally unable to read, or decode, the signs of the female body, and, as Rosemary Jann comments, "feminine sexuality eludes the rational solution of mystery promised by the Holmes stories."[47]

But, more importantly, in his quest, the detective fails to ask some crucial questions. For example, when the King requests "absolute secrecy for two years"[48] in the matter, no reason is given, and Holmes does not question the moratorium. Similarly, when Holmes witnesses an unexpected and singular string of events, culminating in Adler's marriage to Norton, he does not wonder why the man is so agitated, why there is such a hasty wedding, or why the newlyweds go their separate ways right after the ceremony. If Holmes had asked, he may have realized, or at least speculated, that the bizarre incidents were possibly related to Holmes himself. The couple may have discovered the detective's involvement in the case, thus accelerating their plans and forcing them into a rushed marriage and a precipitous departure. Holmes's failure to raise questions and seek answers dooms him, as it did other heroes before him.[49]

In the final analysis, and contrary to the King's assertion, the case is a failure for Holmes, as he becomes a literal and metaphorical fallen hero; he literally falls to the ground to attract Adler's attention, and he metaphorically falls into her trap.[50] But his true downfall stems from

his fatal flaw, his hubris. Watson remarks "so accustomed was I to his invariable success that the very possibility of his failing had ceased to enter into my head."[51] Overconfidence (reinforced by the assumption that a female cannot possibly outsmart him anyway), and not Adler's exceptional cleverness, is what will cause Holmes to lose the case. The detective's tragic downfall (to stay in the realm of the mythical) is reinforced by the underlying theme of death, an unusual reference since the case does not involve a brutal crime. Adler is first introduced as "the late Irene Adler,"[52] yet we never learn the cause of death, and although the relevance of this information is unclear at first, its significance will soon be brought to light.[53] Death is also used idiomatically in describing Adler, "a lovely woman, with a face that a man might die for."[54] Holmes, in his clever mise-en-scène in front of Adler's house, is initially left for dead until someone shouts "he'll be gone before you can get him to hospital."[55] Furthermore, when Holmes conjectures on the provenance of the Monarch's writing paper, he oddly concludes that it is made "not far from Carlsbad. Remarkable as being the scene of the death of Wallenstein."[56]

All the characters in "A Scandal in Bohemia" also suffer a metaphorical or symbolic death (or loss). Adler buries her old life and becomes a respectable married woman; the Monarch mourns the loss of a potentially "admirable queen;"[57] Watson deserts his wife once more to be with Holmes (he mentions that "I slept at Baker Street that night"[58]); Holmes, losing a case for the first time in his career, suffers the deepest loss of all, for the moral wounds he incurs will remain with him forever. But, predictably, images of death are followed by images of birth or rebirth, as symbolized by the timetable of the story. Holmes meets the Ruler on the evening of 20 March 1888, and Adler the next day, the first day of Spring. This date suggests both a death and a rebirth, a renewal, as all the protagonists lives will be forever altered from then on. Adler starts a new life with a new husband in a new country; the King is finally able to marry freely; Holmes and Watson are set for other successful adventures.[59]

The reversal and decentering taking place in "A Scandal in Bohemia" (the male world order turned upside down by foreign classless female),[60] followed by a recentering (the original British upper-class male world order restored in the end), is the embodiment, the illustration of nineteenth-century societal views, of its obsessions, its fears of chaos. As Rosemary Jann notes, "behind the almost compulsive insistence on

orderliness in the Holmes stories we can feel the anxious pressure of instability and disorder."[61] The one common denominator is of course Woman, who is the catalyst, the alpha and the omega of fear. Fear, in this case fear of Woman, is conquered (but not without pain or cost) by Holmes's positivism mixed with a strong dose of misogyny. Chaos (i.e. Woman) is a brief but powerful threat, yet order is ultimately reinstated; and this is achieved through not one but several means, as the following examples will demonstrate.

In the concluding moments, despite all evidence to the contrary, the Monarch belabors the semi-success of the case (see note 50). But more importantly, midway through the story, Adler gets married, and two details are greatly relevant: the church wedding and the groom's profession, as these elements serve as a double legitimating of the former "adventuress." First, the marriage changes her status from harlot to housewife, the religious ceremony (more so than a civil one) sanctifying Adler as a respectable woman. Second, she marries a respectable lawyer, the epitome of law and order, which further seals and establishes her new societal status. Through her marriage, Irene Adler Norton acquires legitimacy in the eyes of God and Men and as such, she is no longer a threat to society in general, or to the King in particular.[62] Yet, there will always remain doubts and the possibility of chaos, as illustrated by Adler's final warning: "I keep it [the photograph] only to safeguard myself, and to preserve a weapon which will always secure me from any steps which he might take in the future."[63] So it does seem that Adler has the last word after all, the upper-hand in the affair. But measures are taken to irrevocably reverse this intolerable, unstable and unnatural position; the woman may have won a few battles, but the men will ultimately win the war. First, Adler does leave the country, assuring that Holmes (and Victorian England) is rid of a potentially dangerous physical presence; but, that not being enough, Adler must become the *late* Irene Adler. This seemingly odd and irrelevant information now takes on full significance. Dead, the former *agent provocateur* can no longer pose a threat to the order of society, and with her disappearance, chaos is safely eliminated.

"A Scandal in Bohemia" is a seminal *fin-de-siècle* work. Its portrayal of an infinitely unstable and chaotic world, with constant fluctuations, shifts, decenterings and reversals of the original order, is an encapsulating illustration of the fears plaguing the last decades of the nine-

teenth century. But, while for a brief time the world is turned upside down by Woman, the ultimate Male world order is finally restored.

Notes

1. Holmes subsequently tells us that "The 'Gloria Scott'" "was the first [case] in which I was ever engaged" *Sherlock Holmes: The Complete Novels and Stories* (New York: Bantam Classic, 1986), I: 510, proving that chronology is not faithfully observed in the stories. As Christopher Clausen remarks in "Sherlock Holmes, Order, and the Late-Victorian Mind," *Georgia Review*, 38:1 (Spring 1984), there are "notorious inconsistencies of biographical detail from one Holmes story to another" (107).

2. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 215.

3. Ibid., 229.

4. Ibid., 228.

5. Ibid., 209, 229.

6. Ibid., 213.

7. Ibid., 217.

8. Ibid., 221.

9. Ibid., 220.

10. Sigmund Freud, *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, James Strachey, ed. (London: Hogarth Press, 1953–74, 24 vols.), 20: 212.

11. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 215.

12. The places are, in order of appearance, Odessa, Holland, Bohemia, Carlsbad, Prague, New Jersey, La Scala (Milan), Warsaw, London and Scandinavia.

13. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 216.

14. Ibid., 228.

15. Jasmine Yong Hall, "Ordering the Sensational: Sherlock Holmes and the Female Gothic," *Studies in Short Fiction* 28:3 (Summer 1991), 301.

16. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 209.

17. Ibid., 219.

18. Ibid., 229.

19. Ibid., 209.

20. Ibid., 223.

21. Ibid., 209.

22. Ibid., 225.

23. Ibid., 215, 213.

24. Pasquale Accardo, *Diagnosis and Detection: The Medical Iconography of Sherlock Holmes* (London: Associated University Presses, 1987), 89. It should be noted that these manoeuvres do help Holmes gain information on Adler; they are thus not used for an "evil" purpose.

25. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 209.

26. Ibid.

27. Ibid., 210.

28. Ibid., 214.

29. Ibid., 211.

30. Ibid., 226.

31. Ibid., 209.

32. *A Study in Scarlet*, I: 15.

33. Holmes always evokes resolution; once he has analyzed a case, he has also solved it. Yet this is not entirely true, as we have seen in "A Scandal in Bohemia." Throughout the stories, there are other occasions of unsolved elements. In "The Musgrave Ritual," for example, a mystery remains. As Holmes points out, "Ah, there you lay your finger upon the one point which we shall probably never be able to clear up" (I: 544). Similarly, in "The Resident Patient" there are some loose ends as "from that night nothing has been seen of the three murderers" (I: 595). In one of the last stories, "The Problem of Thor Bridge," Watson confesses that some cases "and not the least interesting, were complete failures" (II: 564). According to Watson in a parenthetical introduction to "The Yellow Face" (I: 477), there were two cases where Holmes's failure nevertheless led to a successful conclusion: "The Musgrave Ritual" and "The Yellow Face." Watson does not mention "A Scandal in Bohemia."

34. Oddly enough, Holmes is not the only one duped here, the reader is also fooled to a certain extent. The premise we are led to assume from the title, namely that there is a scandal, and that it takes place in Bohemia, is false on both counts. Just as Holmes was fooled by Adler, the reader is in turn fooled.

35. "Charles Augustus Milverton," I: 798. For the sake of brevity, we omit the words adventure or case found in most titles.

36. *The Sign of the Four*, I: 163.

37. *The Valley of Fear*, II: 196.

38. "The Dying Detective," II: 386.

39. "The Disappearance of Lady Frances Carfax," II: 401.

40. "The Greek Interpreter," I: 595. It must be noted that Holmes's alienation from the female gender is not an utter surprise, as he is asocial and unsuited for any type of relationship, be it male or female. This is shown quite plainly in Holmes's relationship with Watson, in the often mocking and condescending way he treats the Doctor.

41. "The Illustrious Client," II: 468.

42. "Femininity" in Sigmund Freud, *The Standard Edition*, 22: 113.

43. This remark, once made by Freud to Marie Bonaparte, cannot be dated with certainty. For more details, see Editor's Note in Sigmund Freud, *The Standard Edition*, 19: 244n1.

44. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 213.

45. Ibid., 210.

46. Ibid., 227.

47. Rosemary Jann, "Sherlock Holmes Codes the Social Body," *ELH* 57: 3 (Fall 1990), 687.

48. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 214.

49. Holmes's situation is a replay of Perceval's quest who, also on his first adventure, does not inquire about the Grail procession he witnesses. Had he asked, he would have not only cured the Fisher King, but he would also have avoided the quest of the Holy Grail. "A Scandal in Bohemia," serves as a transposition of that myth.

50. Indeed as Holmes laments, "I am sorry that I have not been able to bring your Majesty's business to a more successful conclusion," the King enthusiastically and forcefully exclaims "on the contrary, my dear sir . . . nothing could be more successful" (229).

51. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 218.

52. Ibid., 209.

53. The term "late" is rather ambiguous. Another less dramatic interpretation would suggest that the "late Irene Adler" refers to her maiden name as opposed to her married name of Norton.

54. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 220.

55. Ibid., 224.

56. Ibid., 212. What Holmes is referring to is in fact two deaths, a literal and a fictional one. The

real-life Count Wallenstein was assassinated for treason against the King of Bohemia, which inspired Schiller to write *Wallensteins Tod*, a dramatic trilogy, in 1799.

57. Ibid., 229.

58. Ibid., 227.

59. We would like to point out here that the overall mood of the story is positive. Although Holmes is defeated, he reacts like a true Victorian gentleman, for despite a marked sting to his ego, he cannot hide his deep admiration for this exceptional woman.

60. Adler's social status is unclear, though we know what class she does not belong to, as she is unworthy of being a King's bride. As an artist, an adventuress, a *demi-mondaine*, she belongs to a *monde à part*.

61. Jann, 704.

62. The wedding is quite a clever feature, as it elevates Adler's status in society, it also demotes her as a woman, proving the nineteenth-century view that a woman cannot be successful without a man. This marriage illustrates the ultimate defeat of Women.

63. "A Scandal in Bohemia," I: 229.